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Chapter 4

Traces of Indonesian Influences in Tibet

JAN A. SCHOTERMAN

EVER SINCE THE REDISCOVERY by the French scholar George Coëdès (1918) of the Indonesian kingdom of Śrīvijaya, which for more than half a millennium (7th–13th century AD) played a major role in the history of South-east Asia, the study of this polity has assumed a prominent position in the research of the ancient history of Indonesia.¹ This kingdom and its capital Śrīvijayapura, probably located near the modern city of Palembang in Sumatra, functioned for a long period as a relay station and resting point in the vibrant sea trade between India and China, to which it also contributed an array of products. Apart from this, Śrīvijaya also maintained close contacts with kingdoms on the mainland of Southeast Asia. Its important position in Asian commercial traffic aside, Śrīvijaya was for many centuries a prominent international centre in the Buddhist world. Chinese monks, on their way to India by sea, often stayed in the capital of Śrīvijaya for some length of time to familiarize themselves with Sanskrit before travelling on to India. Of these Chinese monks the best known was perhaps Yijing, who stayed in the capital for a period of six months in the year 671. However, *bhikṣus* from India itself also did travel to the famous Śrīvijaya. Thus we read in Tāranātha's *History of Buddhism in India* (in Tibetan, 16th century) that, after his retirement from Nālandā University, Dharmapāla, originally from Kāñcī and a contemporary of Xuanzang, left for Sumatra to stay there for the rest

of his life. According to this late Tibetan source he gained immortality (*amṛtasiddhi*) there, never to be reborn again. This Dharmapāla followed the spiritual tradition of the famous Buddhist scholar Dīnnāga (5th century), who in turn is mentioned in the Old Javanese *San̄ Hyañ Kamahāyānikan* as the proclaimer of the fourfold Yoga.

Because of the many foreign contacts, both commercially and in religious matters, it almost goes without saying that non-Indonesian sources could contain important information regarding the history of Śrīvijaya. Apart from indigenous sources (inscriptions, artefacts, etc.), the Chinese in particular have contributed much to our knowledge of the kingdom of Śrīvijaya. The reports of pilgrims as well as the more official documents of the many Chinese embassies offer a wealth of information, although a correct interpretation of the data is hampered by the Chinese transcription of the Indonesian (mostly Sanskrit) names. In stark contrast to this is the meagre information from Indian sources. These sources yield little more than the Indian name for the Archipelago, the Island of Gold [*suvarṇadvīpa*], and the rich mines found there. Factual information is hardly ever offered. Next to the information from Chinese, Indian and—not to be overlooked—Arab and Persian sources, there is yet another foreign category in which to find information about Śrīvijaya, namely the vast Tibetan literature. Having once been an important Buddhist centre, it is not surprising that Śrīvijaya is mentioned as such in Tibetan texts, although in general the information therein cannot be called abundant. The exceptions are the writings by or about the Tibetan saint Atiśa (982–1054), one of the most prominent saints of Tibet, who for a period of twelve years stayed in Sumatra at the court of Śrīvijaya.

1. The original paper, *Indonesische Sporen in Tibet*, was presented by J. Schoterman (1948–89) as a lecture at a meeting of the Dutch Oriental Society in Leiden on 18 March 1985, and subsequently published by E.J. Brill, also in Leiden (Schoterman 1986). The present English translation was a joint effort by Roy Jordaen and Mark E. Long.

In any discussion about Buddhism the mention of the name Tibet often has a nearly magical effect in which one is apt to lose sight of the fact that it is precisely Tibet which converted to Buddhism at a relatively recent date. In order to view the matter from a correct perspective it seems wise to devote a few remarks to the spread of Buddhism in Asia in general and in Indonesia in particular.

At the Council of Pāṭaliputra (AD 245), under the auspices of the Emperor Aśoka, it was decided to disseminate the Buddhist doctrine universally. Relying on the texts, monks were dispatched to almost every known country to preach Buddhism successfully. However, the only thing that is certain is that the *bhikṣu* Mahendra arrived in Sri Lanka to teach the Doctrine shortly after the Council. Khotan, located on the southern Silk Road, must also have come into contact with Buddhism at an early date. As is so often the case, religion and commerce went hand in hand and therefore it is not surprising that Buddhism also reached China at the beginning of the Common Era via the Silk Road. One Lokāṣema, a Yüeh-chih, is credited with the introduction of Mahāyāna Buddhism in China (see Zürcher 1972: 35). After Buddhism had gained foothold in China, Japan also came into contact with Buddhism in the year 552, when the Korean King Songwang sent a Buddha statue and a few manuscripts to the Japanese emperor. The dissemination of Buddhism in Southeast Asia and Indonesia in particular is less clearly traceable. Contacts between India on the one hand and Southeast Asia on the other presumably existed from very early times onwards but are only clearly discernible at the beginning of the Common Era and, once again, primarily concern commercial interests. As gold in India itself is only found in small quantities (the goldfields near Kolar), from time immemorial the Indians used to import gold from Central Asia and Siberia, but in the last two centuries before the Common Era this was impossible due to the turmoil triggered by the large population movements in Central Asia. Consequently vast amounts of gold coinage were imported from Rome, apparently in such huge numbers that the Emperor Vespasianus (69–79) was compelled to prohibit any further exports. Out of sheer necessity gold was looked for in other areas, including the Indonesian

Archipelago. Although gold had perhaps been the main motive, other products were also appreciated. This is apparent from the (Sanskrit) names given to the different new areas. Thus we hear among other things of Camphor Island, Coconut Island, etc. Gold Island fits in this series, designating Sumatra, but not exclusively. 'Gold Island' is the literal translation of the Sanskrit *suvarṇadvīpa*, being used side by side with 'Gold Land' (*suvarṇabhūmi*). The latter probably designates Pegu in Burma. It is against this background that the dissemination in Indonesia of Buddhism, and of course also of Hinduism, should be understood. The monks and priests who joined the lengthy sea voyages earned their position on board not least because of their knowledge of the stars and medicine. When exactly Buddhism reached the Archipelago cannot be determined. The oldest traces of Hinduism (and gold) are found on Kalimantan, where are the well-known Kutai inscriptions of King Mūlavarman, dating to around the year 400 (de Casparis 1975: 14ff.). We may assume that Buddhism also reached Indonesia in this period. In support of this contention the fact is often mentioned that early Buddha statues have been found in widely separated places such as Sempaga in Sulawesi, Jember (Java) and Seguntang (Sumatra). Both the geographical dispersion and the early date assigned to these statues (4th–5th century; see Coédès 1968: 18) would point to an early and wide presence of Buddhism in the Archipelago. Recently, however, it has been rendered plausible that these statues date from a much later period, presumably the 8th or 9th century (see Barrett 1954: 41ff.). Even so, it seems beyond doubt that Buddhism was present in the Archipelago at an early date and almost simultaneously with Hinduism, although in the beginning Hinduism may have enjoyed a greater popularity. Perhaps the report of the Chinese pilgrim Faxian, who visited the Archipelago in 414 (Coédès 1968: 54–55), sheds light on this. Faxian stated to his regret that Buddhism was not yet influential in contrast to the flourishing community of 'heretic Brahmins' (see Krom 1931: 82).

In light of the above, the introduction of Buddhism in Tibet occurred at a relatively late date. Although it cannot be excluded that in incidental cases Tibet had gotten into touch with Buddhism from Central Asia, China, or Nepal even earlier (see

Tucci 1970: 13), it was probably only during the reign of King Songtsen Gampo (617–50) that Buddhism was introduced there. It will be generally known that Tibet and Tibetan Buddhism soon acquired a great authority within the Buddhist world. Still, it is worth knowing that there had been Buddhists in the Indonesian Archipelago long before the introduction of Buddhism in Tibet. Therefore, it seems like false modesty when it was stated during a symposium in Jakarta on Śrīvijaya that Buddhism in Śrīvijaya would have been influenced by Tibetan Buddhism (Suleiman 1978: 59; Satari 1979: 88). If indeed there has been some form of influence, then it would have been the other way around, as we will presently see.

As was already observed, most of the information on Śrīvijaya is found in Tibetan texts dealing with the saint Atiśa (982–1054). Originating from northeast India, Atiśa stayed in Sumatra at the court of Śrīvijaya for twelve years (1013–25). It was rather chaotic in northern India, especially in this period. From Ghaznī, a fortress south of Kabul, Mahmūd of Ghaznī launched several attacks against India, in 1018 almost reaching Benares (which he plundered in 1033) and attacking Somnāth (Kathiawar) in 1024. The northeastern part of India, along with the famous Buddhist University in Nālandā, still remained spared, but unrest undoubtedly would have penetrated into this region. Although the Buddhism in northeastern India during this period was not yet directly confronted with Islam, it was highly susceptible to infiltration by various Tantric currents, as a result of which ‘classical’ Buddhism virtually disappeared. It is not difficult to imagine that Śrīvijaya took over the role of northeast India in this period. There one could study classical Buddhism in peace. Representative in this context is an illustrated manuscript of the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā* from the year 1015 (Foucher 1900, 1905), produced three years after Atiśa’s departure for Sumatra. Aside from the text, this manuscript contains a large amount of miniatures of Buddhist divinities and sanctuaries. Most of the illustrations relate to India itself, but a few foreign sanctuaries are also listed. Sri Lanka, for instance, is thrice mentioned and depicted. As for the Indonesian Archipelago, three localities are depicted along with the following captions: (1) ‘On the island of

Java is Dīpaṅkara (= an early Buddha), (2) ‘On the island of Sumatra in Śrīvijayapura is Lokanātha (= Avalokiteśvara), (3) ‘In Kedah on Mount Vālavatī is Lokanātha’. In the manuscript’s series of shrines the absence of Nālandā is striking. The fame in India which Śrīvijaya enjoyed in this period is apparent but was of limited duration. Weakened by the attacks from southern India at the hands of the Cōḷas (see Coedès 1968: 141ff.), Śrīvijaya lost its prominent position in the Buddhist world. Perhaps this is borne out in another manuscript of the previously mentioned *Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā* (Foucher 1900–5), but which dates from 1071. In this manuscript we also find a series of miniatures of Buddhist sanctuaries in India and beyond. The island of Sri Lanka is again mentioned thrice, which suggests that little changed in the intervening period. As regards the Indonesian Archipelago, however, the picture has radically altered. Only Java is still mentioned. Both Śrīvijaya and Kedah have disappeared from the list of important Buddhist sanctuaries.

As said before, the information on Śrīvijaya in Tibetan sources is, generally speaking, not abundant. Yet, a few more or less salient details are worth mentioning. In a list of eight localities where relics of the historical Buddha are venerated, mention is made of Gold Island (see Das 1973: s.v. *gnas*). Although the Tibetans use the standard translation of the Sanskrit *suvarṇadvīpa*, ‘Gold Island’ (Tibetan *gser gliṅ*), it is not immediately clear that this refers to Sumatra. The other seven places enumerated are all located in India or Tibet. Gold Island is the one exception. In spite of the fact that it could confirm the importance of Sumatra, another interpretation is conceivable. Although it is true that the Tibetan word *gliṅ* is the equivalent of the Sanskrit *dvīpa*, it can also designate a large monastery. In this case it would relate to a ‘Golden Monastery’, not an unusual name for a *viḥāra* in Nepal and Tibet. A clearer reference to Sumatra is found in the *Hevajratantra*. In a list of pilgrimages is mentioned an ‘island yielding gold’ (*Hevajratantra* 1.7.16). In contrast to the common *suvarṇadvīpa* for Sumatra, we here find the expression *cāmikarānvita dvīpa*, which faithfully recurs in the Tibetan version (*gser dan ldan pa’i gliṅ*). The *Yogaratnamālā*, the most important Sanskrit commentary on the Tantra,

leaves little doubt that Sumatra is indeed intended here and gives the usual gloss of *suvarṇadvīpa*.

All in all, it is evident that Śrīvijaya on Sumatra was a renowned centre of Buddhism in the first quarter of the 11th century. From days of old it was a place for studying classical Buddhism frequented by Buddhist pilgrims and scholars. An adventitious circumstance was that Śrīvijayapura was a well-known Buddhist site of pilgrimage. It is not surprising therefore that Atiśa sought refuge here when the situation in northeastern India was no longer favourable for studying classical Buddhism.

As one of the most prominent saints in Tibet, it is understandable that a vast amount of secondary literature has come into existence about Atiśa. His biography is found in various Tibetan texts. Herewith it is notable that hardly any attention is devoted to his stay in Sumatra, which must have been of crucial significance for the training of Atiśa. Almost perfunctorily, the outward journey is referred to as 'dangerous' but hardly anything is said about the stay itself. Here I will confine myself to a short biography of Atiśa while referring others to the study of Alaka Chattopadhyaya (1967) for more detailed information.

Atiśa, a title of honour that he was bequeathed with later, was born into a royal family in Vikramapura (Bengal) in the year 982. At birth he was named Candragarbha. Following his admission to the Buddhist order, in 1001 he received the name Dipaṅkaraśrījñāna. For a period of eleven years he studied the Buddhist doctrine in northeast India, but by force of circumstances in 1012 he left for Śrīvijaya in Sumatra, where, as said, he arrived in 1013 after a dangerous sea voyage. For a period of twelve years (1013–25) he studied at the court of Śrīvijayapura with the teacher Dharmakīrti. In 1025, Atiśa returned to India to become the head of the Vikramaśīla Vihāra in Bengal. At the invitation of the Tibetans, Atiśa left for India in 1040 and, after a short stay in Nepal (1041), reached Tibet in 1042. After a fruitful life he finally died at the age of seventy-two in Netang, a small place ten miles to the southwest of Lhasa.

As said before, little is known of his stay in Sumatra. Actually, we know little more than of his study with the teacher Dharmakīrti. According

to the Tibetan texts translated by Das (1893a), this Dharmakīrti was a Sumatran prince who one day discovered a Buddha statue in a cave. Through his sincere veneration of the Buddha, the Sumatrans had an abundant harvest and spontaneously converted to Buddhism. Longing to know more of the creed, the Sumatran prince left for India, where he stayed for seven years and visited Bodh Gāyā, among other places. From his teacher he received the name Dharmakīrti, 'Fame of the Dharma'. Having returned to Sumatra he became a famous teacher whose reputation was known as far as India. This hagiography more or less follows a well-known pattern: birth into a royal family, a miraculous acquaintance with Buddhism, embracing the Doctrine. It is obvious that Dharmakīrti must have been one generation older than his pupil Atiśa. Whereas Dharmakīrti had gone to northeast India (presumably Magadha) to study the Doctrine, Atiśa went to Sumatra as the situation prevailing in northeast India had completely altered. Of course the reputation of Dharmakīrti also could have played a role in Atiśa's decision to leave for Sumatra. We know from the Tibetan author Sum pa that Atiśa had not been the only pupil of Dharmakīrti. At least three other pupils are mentioned by name: Śānti, Śrī Jñānamitra and Ranakīrti (*Sum pa*, edited by Das 1908: 118). What precisely Dharmakīrti taught his pupils is not recorded, but considering the contents of the seven texts attributed to him this must have been in accordance with the traditional Mahāyānic beliefs as taught by famous teachers such as Nāgārjuna, Maitreyanātha and Candrakīrti (see A. Chattopadhyaya 1967: 95). In view of the position of Śrīvijaya as a centre of classical Buddhism there is little reason to assume that local beliefs or ideas could have exerted any influence. The ultimate reason why Atiśa was subsequently invited to Tibet was for the 'restoration' and purification of Buddhism again so as to be able to overcome the setback that Tibetan Buddhism had suffered from the persecutions initiated by King Lang Darma² (838–42). Apparently, Atiśa had enjoyed such a thorough traditional education as to be entrusted

2 Or King Lang Dharma as it more frequently appears in other historical works (translators' note).

with such a commission—a task that he completed successfully.

When Atiśa left Sumatra in 1025 to return to India, he had a small gold statue of the Buddha in his luggage that he had received from his teacher Dharmakīrti. At the occasion of his death in 1054, the statue and a few other personal possessions were distributed among the monks (A. Chattopadhyaya 1967: 439). If this small gold statue was of Sumatran origin and not brought from India by Dharmakīrti, it would imply that a small Buddha statue from Indonesia might still be found somewhere in Tibet. Far more important than this small gold statue are the manuscripts that Atiśa took with him from Sumatra. These manuscripts, amounting to seven, have survived in Tibetan translation and are recorded as such in the Tibetan Canon (TC). The original texts, which clearly were written in Sanskrit, are undoubtedly lost. That these texts originate from Sumatra and were for a large part recorded by Atiśa from the mouth of his teacher is evident from the different colophons. Without going deeper into the texts themselves at this time, it is possible to make a few remarks so as to indicate their significance.

According to the Index of the Tibetan Canon (Peking edition; ed. Susuki 1955–61) the seven manuscripts contain six different texts; one text is believed to be found in two manuscripts (sc. TC nos. 5338 and 5464). This turns out to be incorrect. The composer of the said Index apparently relied on the colophons of both manuscripts, which indeed are nearly identical. The only difference is that the divinity Mañjuvājra (*'jam pa'i rdo rje*) is mentioned in no. 5338, whereas no. 5464 gives the variant Mañjuśrīvājra (*'jam dpal rado rje*). Both colophons mention the *Śikṣāsamuccayābhisamaya* text. However, a cursory glance over both texts does suggest that we are dealing with two different works. No. 5464 (around 35 lines) is almost three times as long as no. 5338 (around 13 lines). Any remaining doubt is removed when we read the beginnings of both texts, wherein as usual both the Sanskrit (in Tibetan transcription) and the Tibetan are given. The text no. 5338 indeed appears to have the name *Śikṣāsamuccayābhisamaya*, but the other (no. 5464) yields the title *Śikṣāsamuccayakārikā*. As a result of the strong resemblance, in title and

also probably in colophon, between the two texts, the colophon of no. 5338 has also been used for no. 5464. Whether the last text was also brought from Sumatra to Tibet by Atiśa is, however credible, hard to prove for the moment.

The colophons of the two texts in question have created a problem in connection with the kings of Śrīvijaya. In translation the two (nearly identical) colophons read as follows:

Dīpaṅkaraśrījñāna and *bhikṣu* Jayaśīla have translated this text [into Tibetan]. The King of Gold Island, the illustrious Dharmapāla, who had incurred the favour of the Sublime Mañjuvājra, exposed the *Śikṣāsamuccayābhisamaya* to Kamala and Dīpaṅkara.

So we are told that Atiśa (Dīpaṅkaraśrījñāna) translated the said text from Sanskrit into Tibetan with the help of Jayaśīla, a renowned translator—the usual procedure. Next we learn of the name of Atiśa's fellow student, one Kamala. From another colophon we know that his full name was Kamalarakṣita. In the list of Sum pa (page 16) this Kamalarakṣita is not mentioned. What matters, however, is the fact that King Dharmapāla of Gold Island, who must have ruled during Atiśa's stay in Sumatra (see Das 1893b: 31; Krom 1931: 249; A. Chattopadhyaya 1967: 92), assuredly is mentioned in both colophons. Here the most common Tibetan word for 'king', *rgyal po*, is used, thus leaving little doubt as to the existence of a king Dharmapāla. This implies, however, that during the twelfth year of Atiśa's stay in Sumatra three kings must have ruled successively—something that cannot be dismissed out of hand. From one of the colophons of the seven texts (no. 5192) we learn that during Atiśa's stay in Indonesia, the king Cūḍāmaṇivarman reigned in the capital city of Śrīvijayapura. Each of the two Sanskrit names is clearly rendered in Tibetan: Cūḍāmaṇivarman is referred to as *gtsug gi nor bu'i go cha*, and the capital city Śrīvijayapura as *dpal nram par rgyal ba'i groñ*. King Cūḍāmaṇivarman is especially known from the so-called 'Great Leiden Charter', a copperplate inscription from South India rendered both in Sanskrit and Tamil, in which mention is made of a gift by the Cōla king Rājaraṇa I (985–1012) to a Buddhist sanctuary at Nākapattinam, which had been built here by King

Māravijayottuṅgavarman in honour of his father Cūḍāmaṇivarman. In the 'Little Leyden Charter', a shorter South Indian copper plate inscription, we are informed of the exact name of this sanctuary demolished by Jesuits in 1868, namely Śrīśailendracūḍāmaṇivarman Vihāra (see Vogel 1919: 630; Krom 1931: 236 ff.; Coedès 1968: 141 ff.). King Cūḍāmaṇivarman was thus succeeded by his son Māravijayottuṅgavarman. The latter must have been succeeded by Dharmapāla, known from the Tibetan colophons. Although it is very well possible that the said three kings ruled over Śrīvijaya during the 1013–25 period, it is remarkable that in this case Cūḍāmaṇivarman and Dharmapāla are mentioned in the Tibetan colophons, but not Māravijayottuṅgavarman. Also worth noticing is that the first two kings bear a name ending in *-varman*, which is not unusual in this connection, whereas [the name] Dharmapāla clearly deviates from this. Lastly, it seems that a king would not be the first eligible person to expound a Buddhist text to two monks. All in all, one can call into question this king Dharmapāla of Gold Island, whose name is not recorded in any epigraphic or Chinese source. The only scholar who entertained doubts as regards King Dharmapāla was J. Naudou (see Coedès 1968: 325, n. 87). That Naudou's doubts were justified is borne out by a closer examination of the colophons.

In the colophons of the works that Atiśa took with him and translated, his Sumatran teacher is mentioned several times. Only once is he referred to as Dharmakīrti, twice as 'Dharmapāla, the guru of Gold Island', and again twice as 'The guru of Gold Island'. Apparently, the Sumatran teacher was known both as Dharmakīrti and Dharmapāla. In this connection it seems obvious that the suspect king Dharmapāla was in reality this teacher. The mention of the title 'king' remains problematic, however. Although it might refer to the royal descent of Dharmakīrti/Dharmapāla, this seems hardly plausible. Rather, here one must assume that the Tibetan *rgyal po* (Skt. *rāja*, 'king') stands for the longer **rgyal po'i bla ma* or *rgyal po gu ru*, which in India as well as in Indonesia is the title of an adviser or minister of the king, particularly in the field of religion (Skt. *rājaguru*). This hypothesis is confirmed in the colophon of a work by Atiśa

himself. In the colophon of the *Satyadvayāvatāra* (TC no. 5298) Atiśa refers to his teacher as the 'Rājaguru of Gold Island' (*gser gliṅ rgyal po gu ru*).

From the above it may be concluded that Atiśa's teacher in Sumatra was no ordinary instructor, but the incumbent of the highest religious position at the court of Śrīvijaya, namely the 'minister of religious affairs'. That the Rājaguru indeed held a very important position can be inferred, for instance, from the inscription on the Ligor stele (AD 775) which states that the king of Śrīvijaya had three brick temples erected and that the Rājaguru (here Rājasthavira; see Vogel 1919: 633ff.), named Jayanta, erected three more *stūpas*. According to the Kalasan inscription (AD 778), King Panaṅkaran [of Java] had a temple for Tārā built at the instigation of the Rājaguru(s).³

Considering the actual content of the six or seven texts that Atiśa took with him, I will be brief. Four (or five) texts are technical and deal with subjects that are fully in line with classical Mahāyāna Buddhism. The other two texts are so-called *sādhana*s, manuals detailing the correct rules for the veneration of a particular deity/divinity. Of both texts it is stated in the colophon that they were made by the *guru* of Gold Island himself. As such, these two *sādhana*s are the only two known examples of this genre from Indonesia. The one *sādhana* concerns the Bodhisattva Acala (TC no. 3883), whereas the other pertains to Krodhagaṇapati (TC no. 4994). The latter *sādhana* is especially remarkable. Generally speaking, each *sādhana* is often known in various versions that, as far as the Sanskrit versions are concerned, are mainly found in the *Sāadhanamālā* and for Tibetan versions in the [Tibetan] Canon. However, the *Krodhagaṇapatisādhana* exists in the form of one text only, namely that of the guru of Gold Island. Closer inspection of the said *sādhana* yields some interesting information. Although Gaṇapati or Gaṇeśa, the well-known god with the elephant head, is indeed

3. Note from the translators: Schoterman writes 'his' Rājaguru(s), meaning Panaṅkaran's Rājaguru, but his interpretation is disputable. The Kalasan inscription itself refers to the Rājaguru(s) of an unnamed Śailendra king whose identification with the Javanese King Panaṅkaran is still hotly contested in archaeological circles and is in need of further substantiation.

the only divinity mentioned in this text, that two gods are involved is clearly shown through the ritual and the mantra used. Within one [and the same] *sādhana* is combined the veneration of both Gaṇapati and Jambhala, the Buddhist god of wealth. Furthermore, it is noteworthy that a segment from the ninth chapter of the *Bhūtaḍāmaratantra*, a text of mainly magical contents, of which there exists both a Buddhist and a Hindu version, is cited in the *sādhana*. The Buddhist version definitely is of respectable antiquity (first half of the 7th century; see Goudriaan 1981: 118).

In the above we have already referred briefly to the construction of a temple for the goddess Tārā, as reported in the Kalasan inscription of AD 778. The goddess Tārā assumes an important position, at least according to the Tibetan sources, in light of the relationship between Tibet and Indonesia. Tārā, more or less the national goddess of Tibet, allegedly would have revealed herself especially through the line of Dharmakīrti of Gold Island and his pupil Atiśa, whereby the latter would have introduced the Tārā cult in Tibet. About this, a Tibetan source says the following: 'Here in Tibet five traditions have come down to us. The most important is Atiśa's School. Both he and his own teacher, Dharmakīrti of Gold Island, continuously saw the face of the Noble Lady (i.e., Tārā) and they both expounded the tradition. Hers is the first of the traditional schools introduced in our country' (see Beyer 1973: 417ff.). From this and other Tibetan sources (Beyer 1973: 14ff.), it is clearly shown that the goddess Tārā first revealed herself to Dharmakīrti who then passed on the tradition to Atiśa. Although the information from Tibetan sources stresses the importance of the Guru from Gold Island in relation to Tibetan sources, these claims should not be accepted at face value.

For if we accept the Tibetan information it would imply that the cult of Tārā was introduced from Śrīvijaya into Tibet only after AD 1042. Although this view is hardly tenable, it may contain a kernel of truth. The most common tradition about the introduction of Tārā in Tibet centres around the time of King Songtsen Gampo (617–50), during whose reign Buddhism gained firm footing in Tibet (see above, p. 115). For political reasons, according to indigenous sources, the king married a Nepalese

princess and a Chinese princess, who were both regarded as incarnations of Tārā (see Tucci 1962: 121–26). As part of the wedding gifts, the Nepalese wife brought a sandalwood statue of Tārā to Tibet where it was erected in a temple. Beyer rightly observes that a widespread veneration of Tārā could not yet have existed in this early period and that the statue was erected in the temple largely for political motives (Beyer 1973: 6). Still, it is clear that the goddess Tārā was known in Tibet from as early as the first half of the 7th century. Seen in this light, the claims in the Tibetan sources that it was Atiśa who introduced Tārā in Tibet should rather be understood as referring to the beginnings of a widespread Tārā cult, which must have been less important and/or had suffered from the persecutions initiated by King Lang Darma prior to Atiśa.

From the biographies of Atiśa, it appears that he had a close relationship with Tārā from an early age. Thus it becomes understandable that it was precisely Tārā who appeared to him in a vision to renounce royal power and search for a teacher in another country (see Roerich 1949 and 1953: 242). Everything points to the fact that Atiśa was a devout adherent of Tārā long before his visit to Śrīvijaya. It is known that the goddess Tārā was venerated in Northeast India long before Atiśa's time. One of the earliest references is found in the itinerary of the Chinese pilgrim Xuanzang, who travelled in India between 633 and 645. He reports to have seen two statues of To-lo (i.e., Tārā) in the environs of Nālandā. Another 'early' Tārā from the region is a statue of the goddess dating from about AD 845 and originating from Hilsa (Patna; Sircar 1967: 128). Inscribed on this statue is the mantra OM TARE TUTTARE TURE SVĀHĀ, which still is the most important mantra in the cult of Tārā up to this very day.

There is, clearly, little reason to regard Śrīvijaya in Sumatra as the place of origin of the cult of Tārā, thence finding its way to Tibet. Atiśa was already familiar with Tārā before his arrival in Sumatra, and Dharmakīrti is almost automatically mentioned in this connection for the simple fact that he was Atiśa's teacher. Here we should not forget that Dharmakīrti himself spent seven years in northeast India studying Buddhism and that he may have learned about the Tārā cult existing there.

Even though it is not very likely that Tārā revealed herself in Śrīvijaya to Dharmakīrti, who passed on the tradition to his pupil Atīśa, we cannot rule out the possibility that the cult of Tārā was known in Indonesia at an early date. The Sanskrit inscription of Kalasan from 778, which mentions the construction of a temple for Tārā (*tārābhavana*) in the plain of Prambanan, is actually one of the earliest extant references to a Tārā cult.

In summary, we could advance the supposition that Atīśa found a long-existing Tārā cult upon his arrival in Śrīvijaya in 1013, as a result of which his own interest in the goddess was further strengthened. Aside from this, his teacher Dharmakīrti could have contributed to the enthusiasm and the diligence with which Atīśa later propagated the veneration of Tārā in Tibet.

A final point relating to the relationship of Indonesia and Tibet concerns the possible existence of a monument in memory of Dharmakīrti in Tibet. The Tibetan monk Mkhyen brtse (1820–92) compiled a sort of religious travel guide for pilgrims who wanted to visit the holy places in central Tibet. To assist these pilgrims he presents a list of the sanctuaries and what can be found inside the walls of Ü, the central province of Tibet with the capital Lhasa. First mentioned by Mkhyen brtse is the famous monastery Reting (*rva sgren*) to the northeast of Lhasa. According to the guidebook, the relics of *bla ma gser gliṅ pa*, of *jo bo*, and of *'brom ston pa rgyal ba'i byun gnas* are to be found inside the walls of the said monastery. There is no doubt as regards the identification of the latter two individuals. Jo bo (Skt. *ārya*) refers to Atīśa, his usual name in Tibet. The last 'Brom ston (1003–63) is the most important pupil of Atīśa. Certainly, the Reting monastery harbours the relics of Atīśa and his pupil 'Brom ston.

As already said (p. 116), Atīśa died in 1054 at Netang (*sñe than*), a small place to the southwest of Lhasa. After his cremation the major part of Atīśa's ashes were installed in a *stūpa* there. In the 20th century the tomb was visited by Waddell in 1904 (Waddell 1905: 320ff.) and by Sir Charles Bell (1931: 58, followed by a photograph of the said tomb). However, the guidebook mentions Reting as the place where Atīśa's relics are found. Apparently, the relics or a part thereof were transferred

to Reting (Ferrari 1958: 77, n. 3). Three years after Atīśa's demise, Reting monastery was founded in 1057 (Tucci 1970: 41) by his pupil 'Brom ston at the instigation of his teacher. It seems plausible that the relics of the founder, 'Brom ston, are kept in the monastery, and that the same 'Bron ston also ordered the transfer of the relics of his own teacher to Reting. After all, Atīśa was a very important and popular figure and the interment of his relics would only add to the fame of the monastery. The question remaining is the identity of *bla ma gser gliṅ pa* whose relics are safeguarded in the Reting monastery next to Atīśa and 'Brom ston.

In her notices on this *bla ma gser gliṅ pa*, Alfonsa Ferrari observes that it probably refers to Gser gliṅ pa Bkra śis dpal, who was born in Gser gliṅ and lived from 1292 until 1365 (Ferrari 1958: 78, n. 6). In fairness to Ferrari, I must add that she states in a note that 'there also was a bla ma Gser gliṅ pa (Suvarṇadvīpika), master of Atīśa, but since he was an Indian teacher (in fact, this is but a surname of Dharmakīrti—L[uciano] P[etech]) it seems impossible to me that his relics should be preserved here'. Obviously the views of Alfonsa Ferrari will not be endorsed here. Firstly, the 'master of Atīśa' was not an Indian teacher but originated from Sumatra, in spite of the fact that Luciano Petech clearly confuses Dharmakīrti of Gold Island with the famous Buddhist logician Dharmakīrti (7th century), who is never said to originate from Gold Island. Aside from this, it seems very unlikely that a rather unknown monk, who lived three centuries after Atīśa, would have been interred in the vicinity of Atīśa and 'Brom ston. It seems more logical to interpret *bla ma gser gliṅ pa* literally and as referring to the guru of Gold Island, meaning Atīśa's teacher Dharmakīrti. This would imply that the relics, or at least parts thereof, of Dharmakīrti in the Tibetan Reting monastery are interred next to the relics of his most renowned pupil Atīśa and the latter's most famous pupil, 'Brom ston. The circle is closed. Ferrari finds it inconceivable that the relics of an Indian teacher of Atīśa were interred here, let alone those of a Sumatran teacher. Yet it is known that Atīśa did take the relics of an Indian teacher with him to Tibet, namely the relics of Nāropā that were interred in a caitya at Netang (see A. Chattopadhyaya 1967: 439). In memory of this, Atīśa is depicted with

a smaller *caitya*. In light of this connection it is no longer odd to suppose the existence of a *stūpa* or *caitya* in the Reting monastery in memory of Dharmakīrti of Gold Island. This would imply that when Atīśa left Śrīvijaya in 1025, his teacher was no longer living. Perhaps the demise of his teacher was the direct cause for Atīśa to return to India. Be

that as it may, Atīśa must have brought a part of the relics with him to India and subsequently to Tibet. If this line of reasoning is acceptable, it would imply that the relics of Dharmakīrti, the Rājaguru of the Sumatran kingdom of Śrīvijaya, are found in the Reting monastery in central Tibet.

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